Maisara Dandamun-Latiph

Atty. Maisara C. Dandamun-Latiph is a distinguished Maranao jurist, legislator, and human rights advocate who has shaped post-conflict recovery and institutional reform across the Bangsamoro region.

Her career spans high-level state legal work, legislative innovation in the Bangsamoro Transition Authority, and executive leadership in one of the Philippines' most consequential reparations programs: the Marawi Compensation Board.

As a Maranao woman in prominent executive and legislative roles, she embodies a modern fusion of traditional Islamic values and progressive legal reform, grounded in an unwavering commitment to peacebuilding and the protection of the marginalized.

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Early Life and Heritage

Atty. Latiph is a member of the Maranao ethnic group and was raised in a Muslim community enclave in Metro Manila during her formative years.

This upbringing in a minority setting, far from the Bangsamoro heartland, sparked her lifelong commitment to educational access and advocacy for the rights and dignity of the Bangsamoro people.

Maisara Dandamun-Latiph



Full Name	Maisara Cudia Dandamun-Latiph
Ethnicity	Maranao
Date of Birth	Not publicly disclosed
Place of Birth	Metro Manila, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Religion	Islam
Education	Masters in Educational Leadership and School Improvement (University of Manchester); Executive Master in National Security Administration (National Defense College of the Philippines); PhD candidate in Educational Administration and Development (University of the Philippines Diliman)
Spouse	Atty. Algamar Latiph
Children	Two
Known For	Human rights advocacy, legislative reform in the Bangsamoro region, leadership of the Marawi Compensation Board
Political Party	Bangsamoro Independent

She credits her family environment with instilling in her a deep sense of responsibility toward community service and nation-building.

Education

Atty. Latiph's academic trajectory reflects a multidisciplinary approach that bridges law, education, organizational leadership, and national security.

She earned her **Masters in Educational Leadership and School Improvement with Honors** from the University of Manchester in the United Kingdom as a prestigious Chevering Scholar.

This achievement positioned her as an educational innovator and policy-level thinker before she fully committed to legal and legislative careers.

She is a pioneering graduate of the **Executive Master in National Security Administration (E-MNSA)** from the National Defense College of the Philippines (NDCP), one of the first women to complete this rigorous program.

Currently, she is pursuing a **Doctor of Philosophy in Educational Administration and Development** at the University of the Philippines Diliman, demonstrating her sustained commitment to advancing knowledge in institutional development and governance.

Professional Career

State Legal Practice

Before transitioning into regional leadership, Atty. Latiph served as a Senior State Solicitor at the Office of the Solicitor General (OSG), where she handled complex constitutional and administrative law matters on behalf of the Philippine government.

This role established her reputation as a skilled legal advocate capable of navigating high-stakes policy disputes and defending state interests while maintaining principled positions on human rights.

Bangsamoro Transition Commission (BTC)

Atty. Latiph served as a Commissioner of the Bangsamoro Transition Commission, the body tasked with drafting foundational legal frameworks for the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).

In this capacity, she contributed substantially to the Bangsamoro Organic Law (BOL) or Republic Act No. 11054, co-drafting key provisions and leading grassroots information campaigns to educate communities about the law and the peace process.

Her work in the BTC positioned her as a bridge between government, civil society, and the communities most affected by decades of conflict.

Bangsamoro Transition Authority (2019-2022)

As a Member of Parliament of the Bangsamoro Transition Authority from 2019 to 2022, Atty. Latiph authored and championed some of the most consequential legislation in BARMM's interim period.

She served as the women sector representative, bringing gendered perspectives and marginalized voices into legislative deliberations.

Her legislative work demonstrates a clear pattern: protecting vulnerable populations and institutionalizing programs that would outlive the transitional government.

Signature Legislative Achievements

Madaris Education Act: Atty. Latiph created the Office of the Director-General for Madaris Education to establish a formal funding and institutional framework for Islamic educational institutions across the Bangsamoro region. This act affirms the importance of Islamic pedagogy while ensuring quality standards and financial accountability.

Bangsamoro Communities outside BARMM (BTA Bill No. 15): She authored legislation creating an office dedicated to protecting the rights and interests of Bangsamoro communities residing outside the autonomous region. This forward-thinking measure addresses the reality that thousands of Bangsamoro citizens live in urban centers and other regions, often isolated from institutional support networks.

RISE Act (BTA Bill No. 157): Promoted social enterprises as vehicles for sustainable development and peacebuilding, recognizing that economic opportunity is inseparable from conflict prevention.

Child Protection and Gender Equality Measures: Atty. Latiph authored numerous bills and resolutions addressing child abuse protection, establishing day care centers, and advancing gender equality in Bangsamoro institutions. These measures reflect her conviction that protecting children and women is foundational to a just society.

Healing Marawi: The Marawi Compensation Board

In January 2023, President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. appointed Atty. Latiph as **Chairperson of the Marawi Compensation Board (MCB)**, the quasi-judicial body mandated to implement Republic Act 11696 or the Marawi Siege Victims Compensation Act of 2022.

The 2017 Marawi siege devastated 32 barangays across the city, displacing over 100,000 residents and destroying an estimated 70 billion pesos in private property and commercial establishments.

For nearly two years, Atty. Latiph led the MCB's effort to receive, adjudicate, and award compensation to qualified claimants.

Operational Milestones

Under her stewardship, the MCB achieved measurable progress in delivering justice and reparations to siege victims:

- **Total Claims Received**: 14,495 individual claims filed with the board
- **Compensation Processed**: Over 1.5 billion pesos disbursed to qualified claimants
- **Approved Claims**: Approximately 2,288 individuals received final awards
- **Payment Efficiency**: The board achieved nearly 100 percent payment fulfillment for approved claims, with payments reaching beneficiaries within six months of approval

The MCB's compensation structure reflected careful deliberation and legal precision:

- Concrete structures: 18,000 pesos per square meter
- Mixed materials: 13,500 pesos per square meter
- Light materials: 9,000 pesos per square meter
- Death claims: Fixed amount of 350,000 pesos per individual

Leadership Philosophy

Atty. Latiph approached MCB leadership with a quasi-judicial mindset, emphasizing rigorous document review, fraud prevention, and equitable treatment of all claimants.

She acknowledged the immense challenge of processing over 14,000 complex claims while maintaining transparent and defensible adjudication standards.

She worked closely with civil society organizations, task forces, and community leaders to ensure the MCB's work reflected the voices and needs of displaced residents themselves.

In March 2025, she transitioned leadership of the MCB to a successor, having established functional systems, trained staff, and secured expanded funding for the board's continued operations.

Educational and Community Initiatives

Beyond legislative and executive roles, Atty. Latiph has founded and directed several educational and advocacy centers that demonstrate her commitment to grassroots empowerment.

She **co-founded the IQRA Kiddie Learning Center** (2003), providing quality early childhood and primary education to Muslim children in Metro Manila.

She established the **Safia Learning Center** (2014), extending educational access to urban Muslim communities often overlooked by mainstream schooling systems.

She founded the **Khadija Center for Muslim Women Studies**, a non-stock, non-profit think tank dedicated to evidence-based research on the lives, challenges, and aspirations of Muslim women in the Philippines.

This center has become a recognized voice in policy advocacy, informing legislation and institutional reform in both national and Bangsamoro governance spaces.

Personal Life and Values

Atty. Latiph is married to **Atty. Algamar Latiph**, a fellow lawyer and human rights advocate with whom she shares a deep commitment to social justice.

Together, they have two children.

The couple represents a prominent legal partnership within the Philippine human rights community, often collaborating on advocacy initiatives and public interest cases.

Atty. Latiph's leadership style is frequently described as independent, principled, and advocacy-driven.

She has stated that her philosophy centers on "giving space" to those at the margins of society: women, youth, children, internally displaced persons, and religious minorities.

She practices Islam thoughtfully and sees no contradiction between Islamic values and progressive legal reform or gender equality.

Legacy and Impact

Atty. Latiph's contributions to Bangsamoro governance extend across three distinct domains: institutional reform through legislation, reparative justice through the MCB, and community empowerment through educational and research initiatives.

Her legislative record demonstrates that peacebuilding requires not just political agreements but concrete institutional investments in education, social safety nets, and economic opportunity.

Her leadership of the MCB showed that complex reparations programs can operate with efficiency, transparency, and respect for claimants' dignity.

Her educational centers and research institute model how Bangsamoro intellectuals can build autonomous knowledge systems that serve community-defined priorities rather than external agendas.

As a Maranao woman navigating male-dominated legal and political institutions, she exemplifies the possibility of change and the power of principled advocacy.

> "Isang malaking karangalan na maglingkod sa Bangsamoro para tugunan ang mandato ng MCB bilang Chairperson" (It is a great honor to serve the Bangsamoro to fulfill the mandate of the MCB as Chairperson). -- Atty. Maisara Dandamun-Latiph, upon stepping down from the MCB chairperson role, March 2025

Her work continues to shape how the Bangsamoro region approaches education, justice, women's empowerment, and the inclusion of marginalized voices in governance.

Further Reading

- Bangsamoro Parliament Official Biosketch. "Member of Parliament Atty. Maisara Dandamun-Latiph." Accessed April 2026. https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph
- Marawi Compensation Board. "Official Statement on MCB Leadership Transition." March 2025.
- Philippine Center for Investigative Journalism. "All Eyes on Maisara Latiph, Who Will Decide Compensation of Marawi Siege Victims." February 2023.
- Philippine News Agency. "Marawi Compensation Board Distributes P841-M to Siege Victims." 2024.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Marawi siege
- Bangsamoro Transition Authority
- Republic Act 11696: Marawi Siege Victims Compensation Act

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